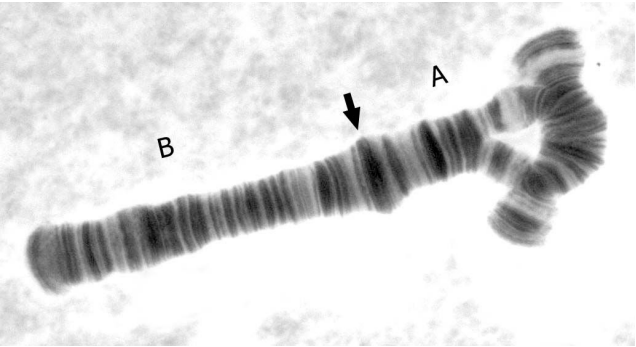
BME 105: Genetics in the Genomics Era

Lecture 8: Linkage and Recombination



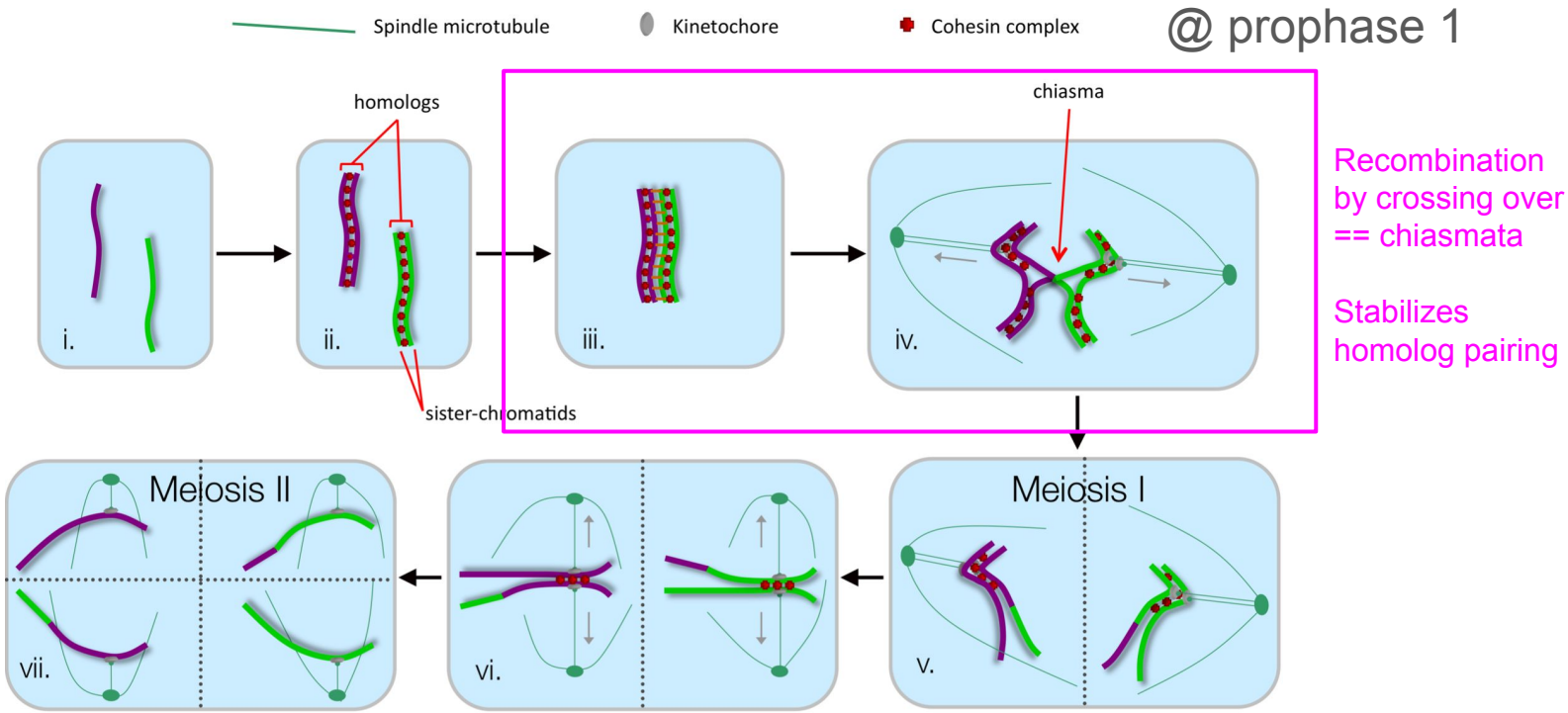
Instructor: Dr. Shelbi Russell,
Assistant Professor

Course website on canvas.ucsc.edu

Lecture 8 Learning Objectives

- Understand how and why reciprocal exchanges between homologous chromosomes (recombination) occurs during meiosis I
  - How: chiasma formation that results in crossing over
  - Why: pairing at metaphase I plate (proximal) and shuffling of allelic variation (ultimate/evolutionary)
- Be able to define genetic linkage and use it to predict trait inheritance
  - Parental haplotypes are more common
  - Recombinant types are expected at some frequency related to the distance between loci
- Be able to calculate the recombination frequency (RF), if given mu and cM
  - Understand that the relationship between mu/cM and physical distance in bp is species-dependent

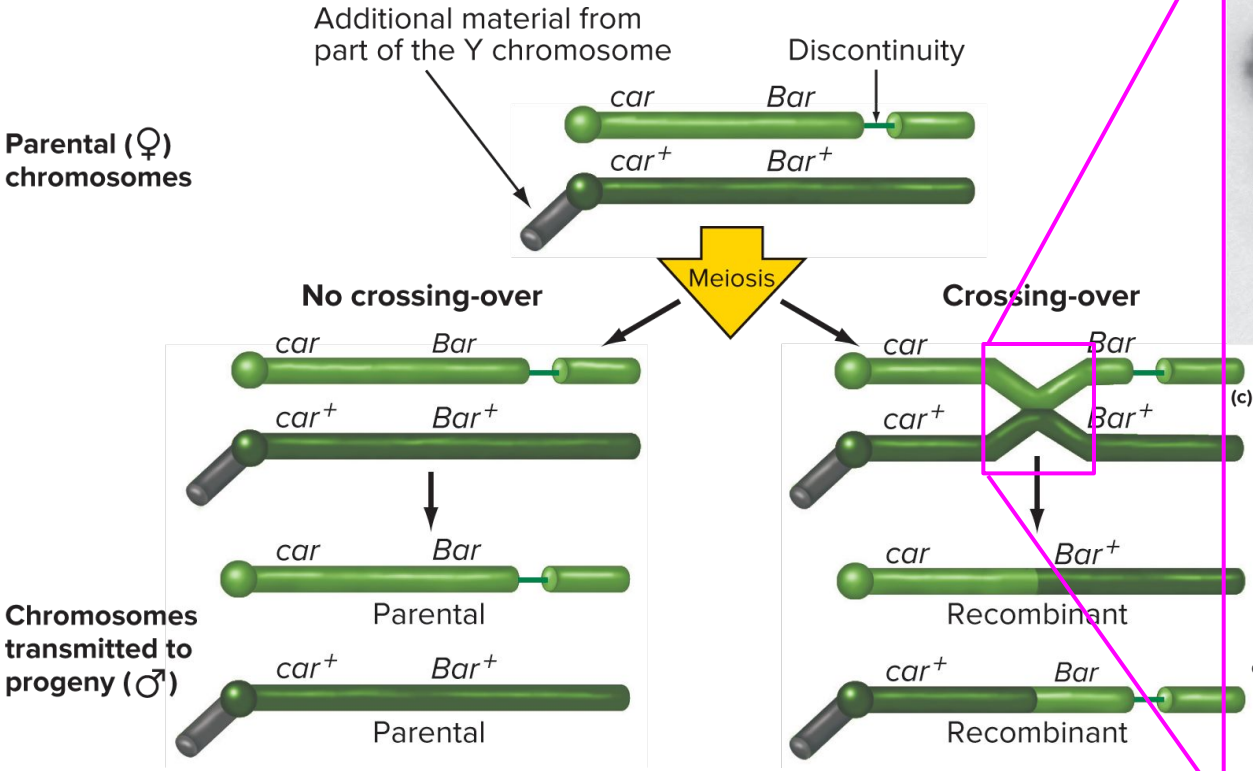
Pairing of homologous and sister chromatids enables proper pairing, segregation, and separation

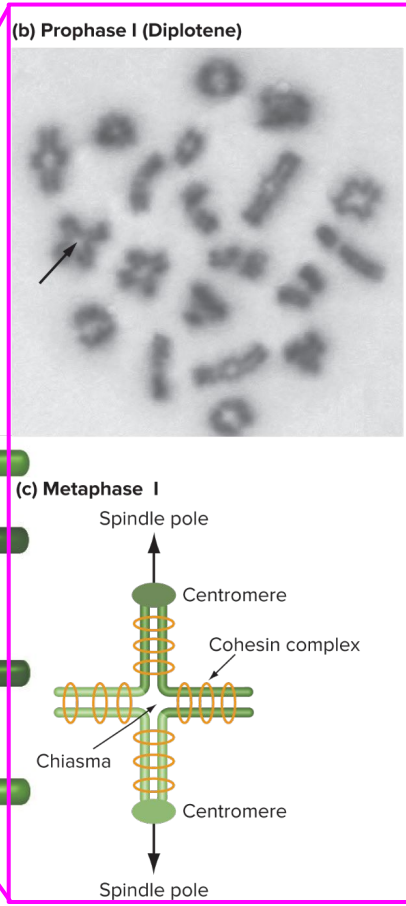


Lao and Hunter 2010 PLoS Biology

@ prophase 1

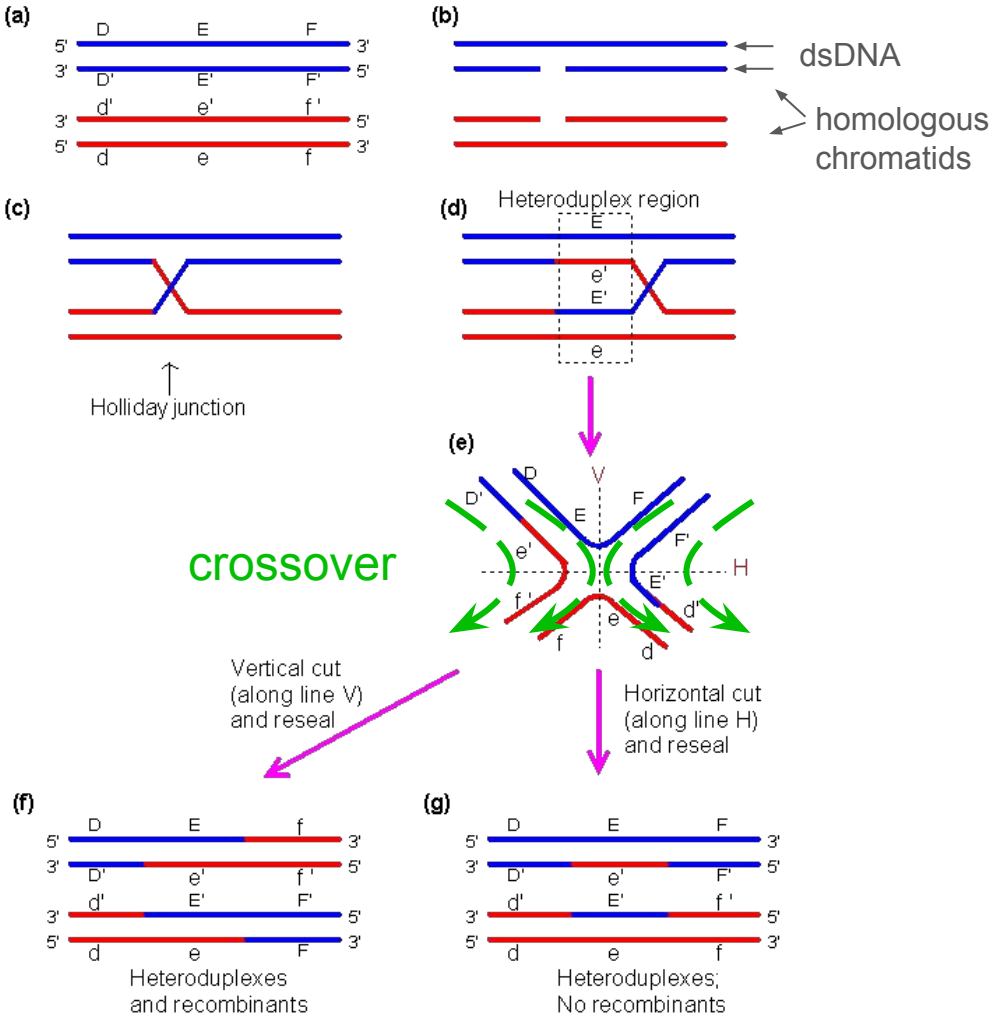
Reciprocal exchanges between homologs are the physical basis of recombination





Chiasmas form Holliday junctions that can resolve in different ways

1) DNA strand break (at identical positions) and homologous strain invasion
2) Holliday junction ~ half chiasma formation
3) Covalent linking of invading to original strands ~ full chiasma
4) Branch migration (orients chiasma)
5) Resolution (crossed strands cleaved and re-ligated)
    a) Crossovers



https://www.biologyexams4u.com/

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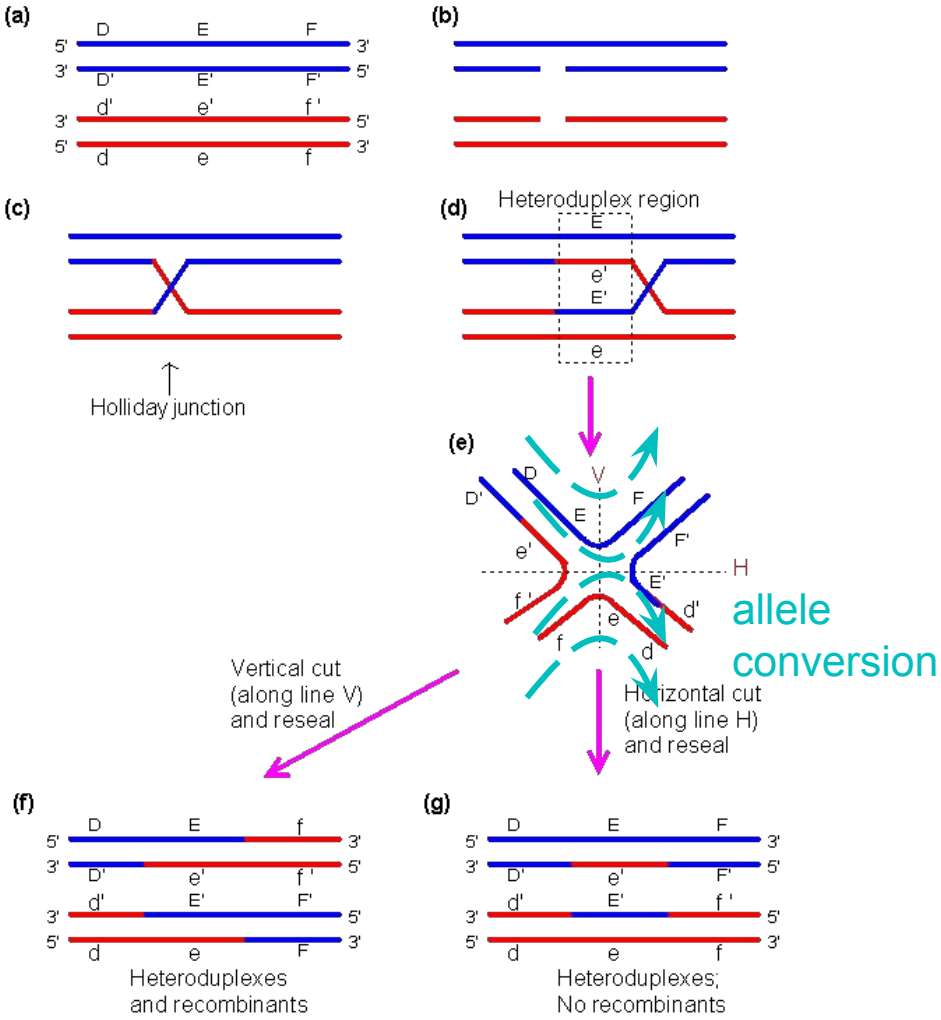
3) Covalent linking of invading to original strands ~ full chiasma
4) Branch migration (orients chiasma)
5) Resolution (crossed strands cleaved and re-ligated)
    a) Crossovers
    b) Heteroduplexes (different sisters)
    c) No recombinants



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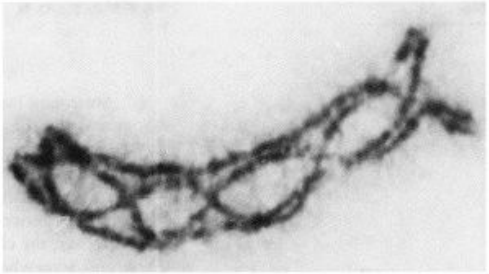
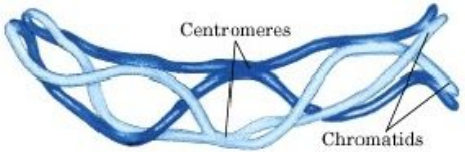
Both sister chromatids of each homologous pair can crossover

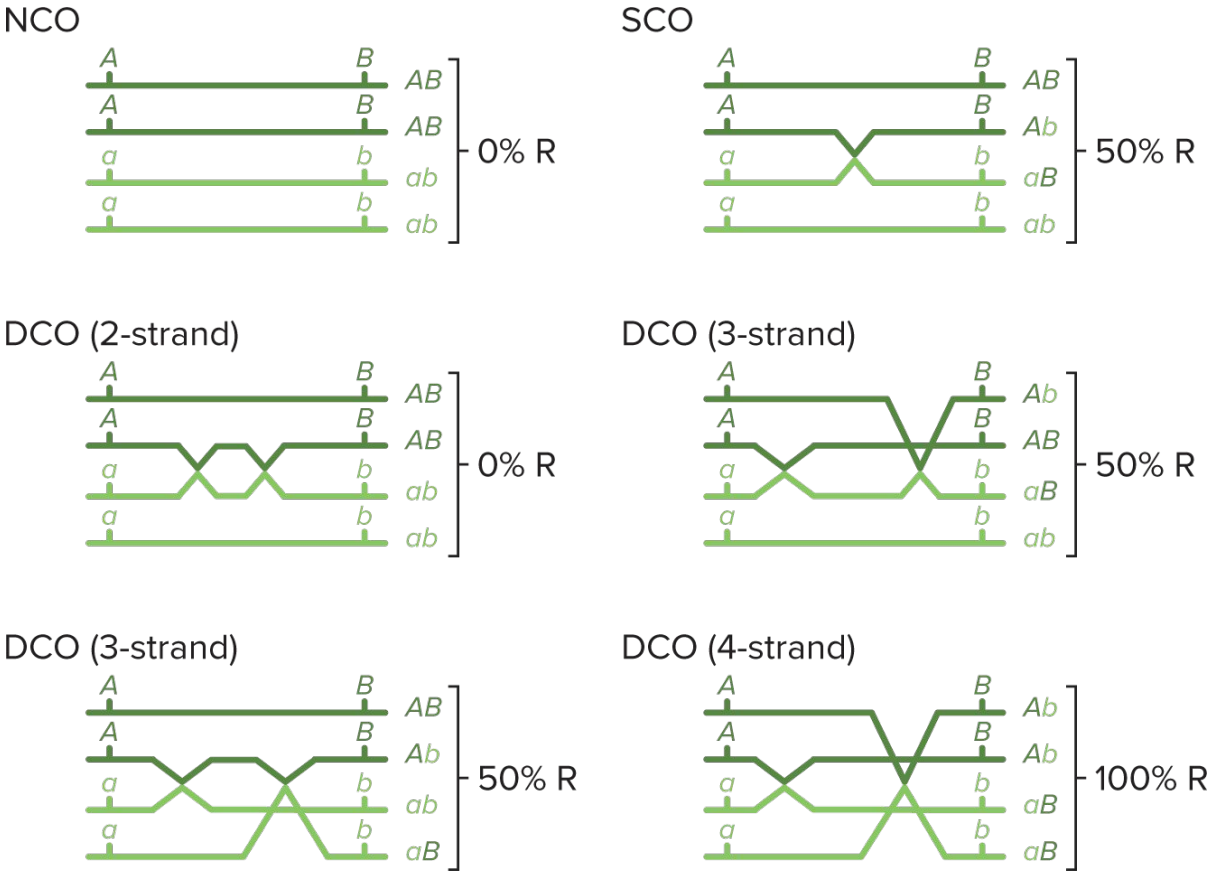


2 μm



(b)

NCO = no crossover
SCO = single crossover
DCO = double crossover

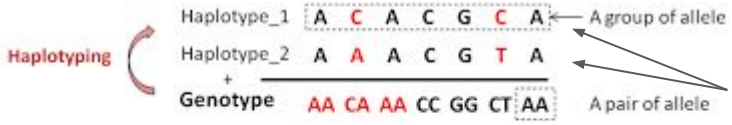


$$\text{DCO average} = \frac{0\% + 50\% + 50\% + 100\%}{4} = 50\%\ \text{R}$$

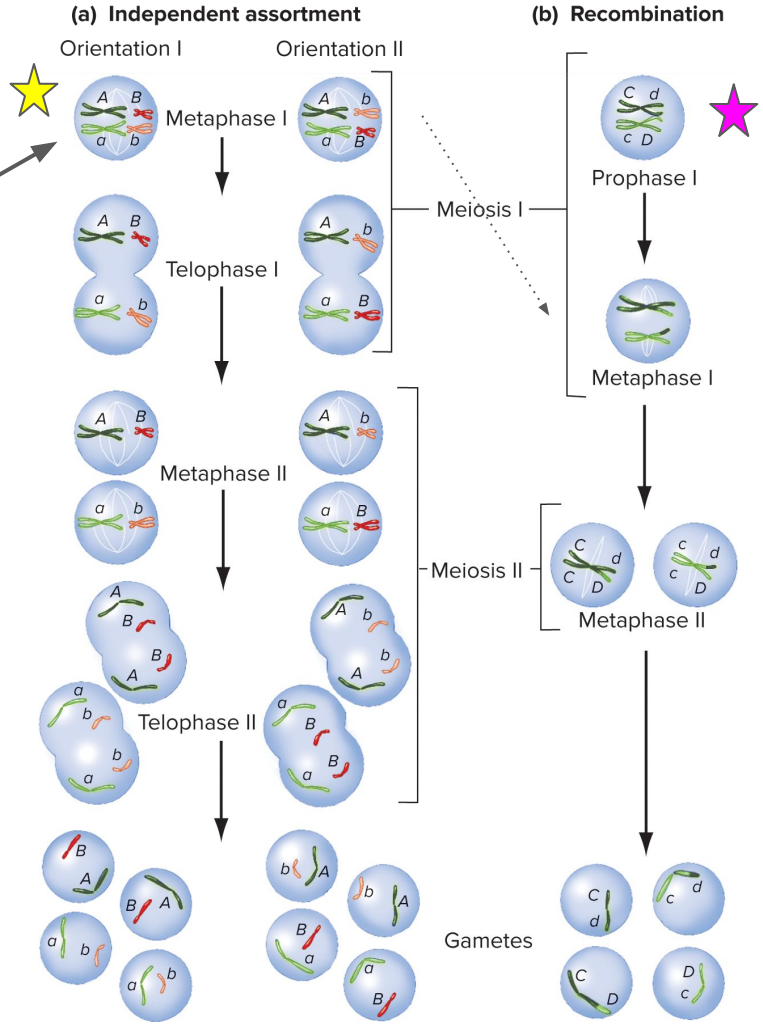
How does meiosis contribute to genetic diversity?

- Independent assortment of different chromosomes in Metaphase I
- Prior to this in meiosis I… homologous chromosomes pair and crossover, inducing recombination.

Meiotic recombination generates **new combinations of alleles** along chromosomal haplotypes.



alleles differ by parental origin



Another X-linked locus was discovered…

w^+ red eyes
w recessive, white eyes

y^+ tan body
y recessive, yellow body

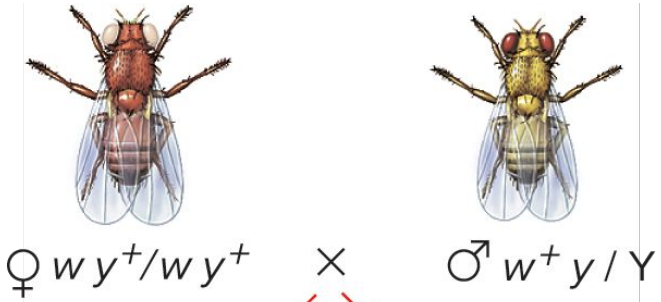
P

	♀ w	♀ w
♂ Y	w/-	w/-
♂ w^+	w^+/w	w^+/w

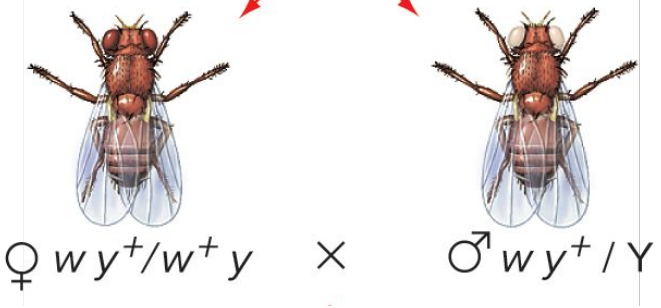
	♀ y^+	♀ y^+
♂ Y	y^+/-	y^+/-
♂ y	y^+/y	y^+/y

This is how the alleles would behave, *if on separate chromosomes* (segregating independently). <u>But are they?</u>
The F1 cross is not diagnostic, but F2 males are…

P

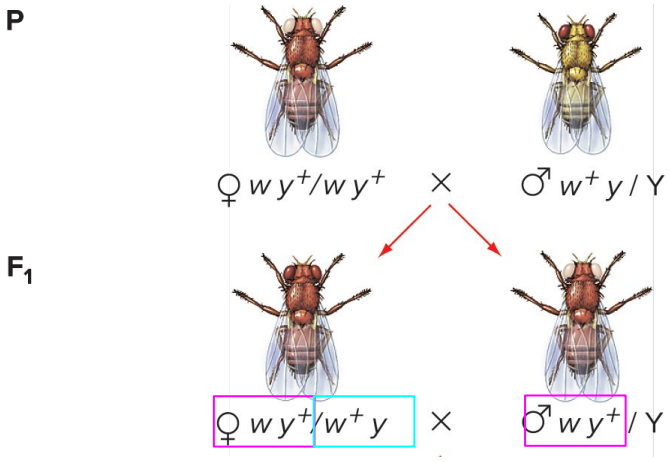


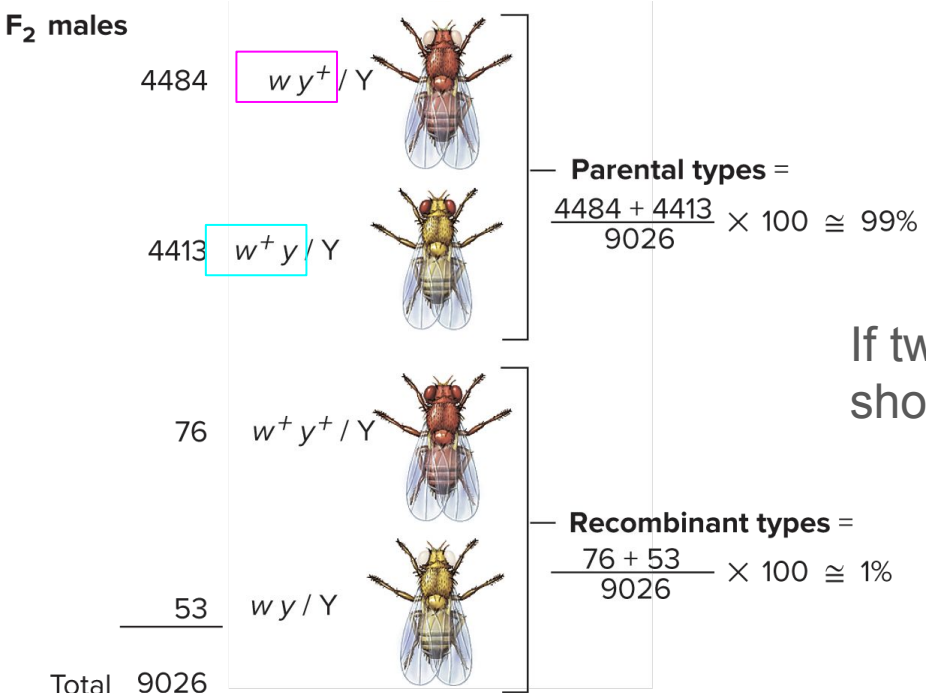
F_1



⇒ 50% female red eye tan body: wy^+/w^+y
⇒ 50% male white eye tan body wy^+/Y

The two X-linked loci were tested for linkage to each other



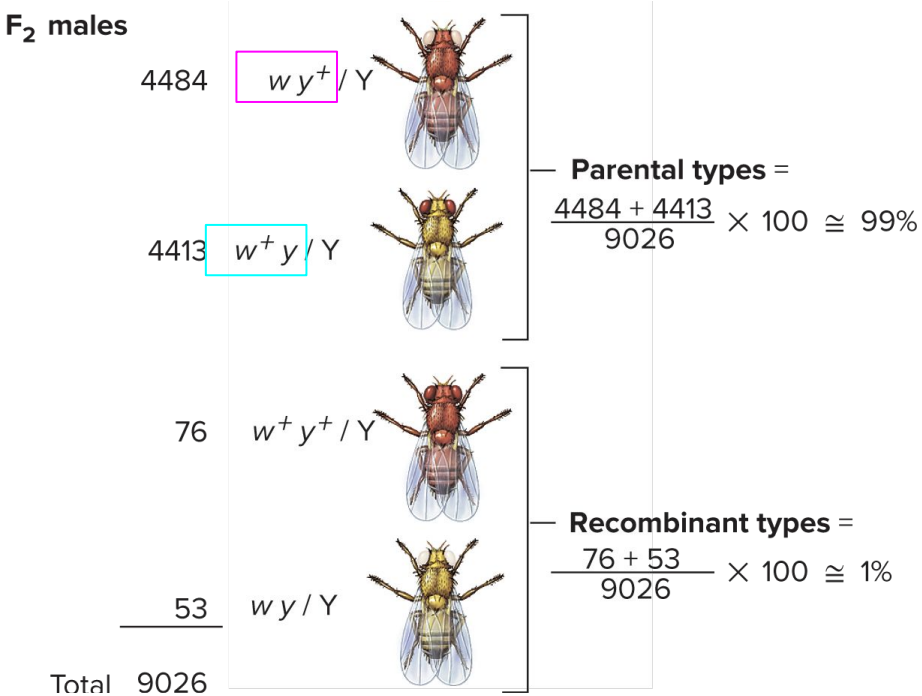


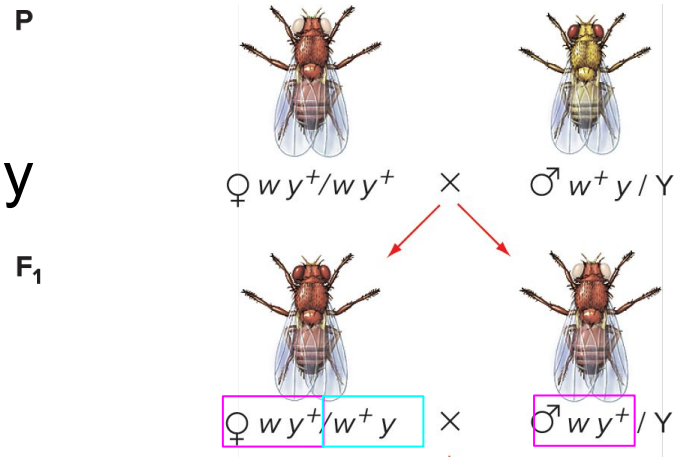
If two loci are unlinked, dihybrid females should make four types of gametes:

wy^+ w^+y w^+y^+ and wy at a ~1:1:1:1 ratio

New combos of alleles!

When genes are linked, parental types occur much more frequently than recombinant types





Conclusions from fly experiments from Thomas Morgan:

- The w and y locus are on the X chromosome, so they are linked.
- Linkage means that the alleles on the same parental chromosomes are more likely to be passed on to the next generation.

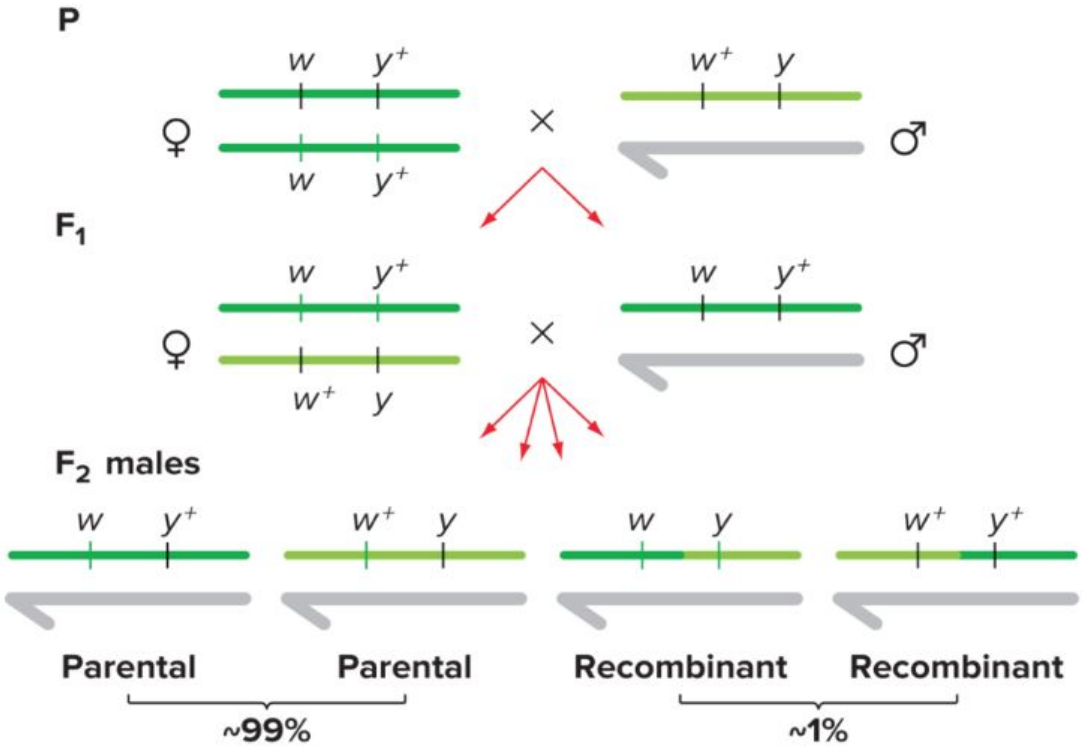
How many males had red eyes and tan bodies in Morgan's experiment?

76/9026 = 0.842%

… very very few

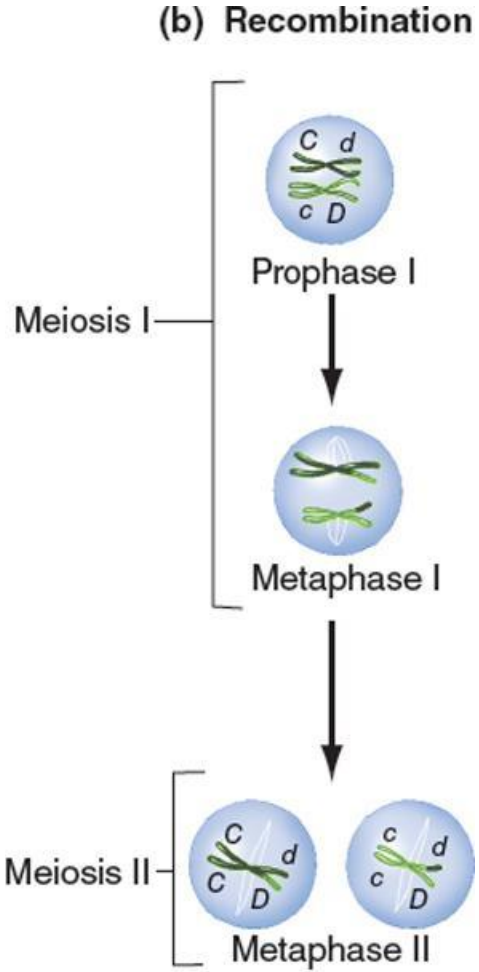
… recombination by locus is rare

When genes are linked, parental combinations occur more often than recombinant types



Recombination: homologous chromosomes cross-over in meiosis I

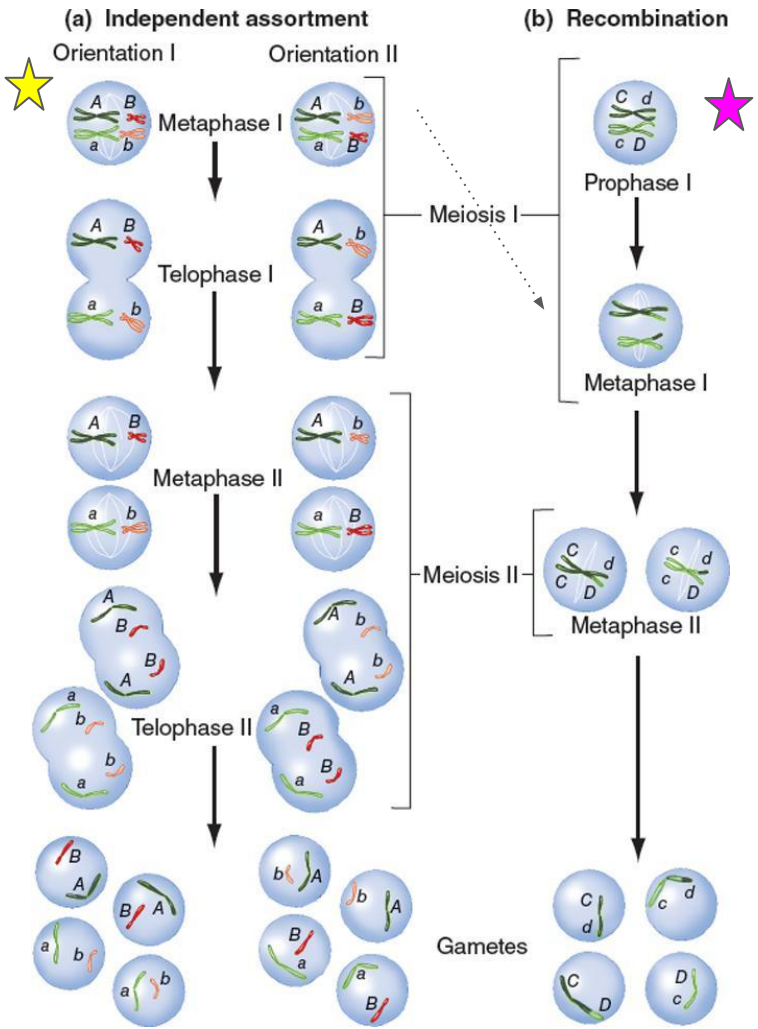
- The appearance of recombinant types is due to crossing over in Meiosis I.
- This creates genetic diversity
  - New allelic combinations



How meiosis contributes to genetic diversity?

Independent assortment of genes on **different chromosomes** in Metaphase I

Recombination between genes on the **same (homologous) chromosome** in Prophase I

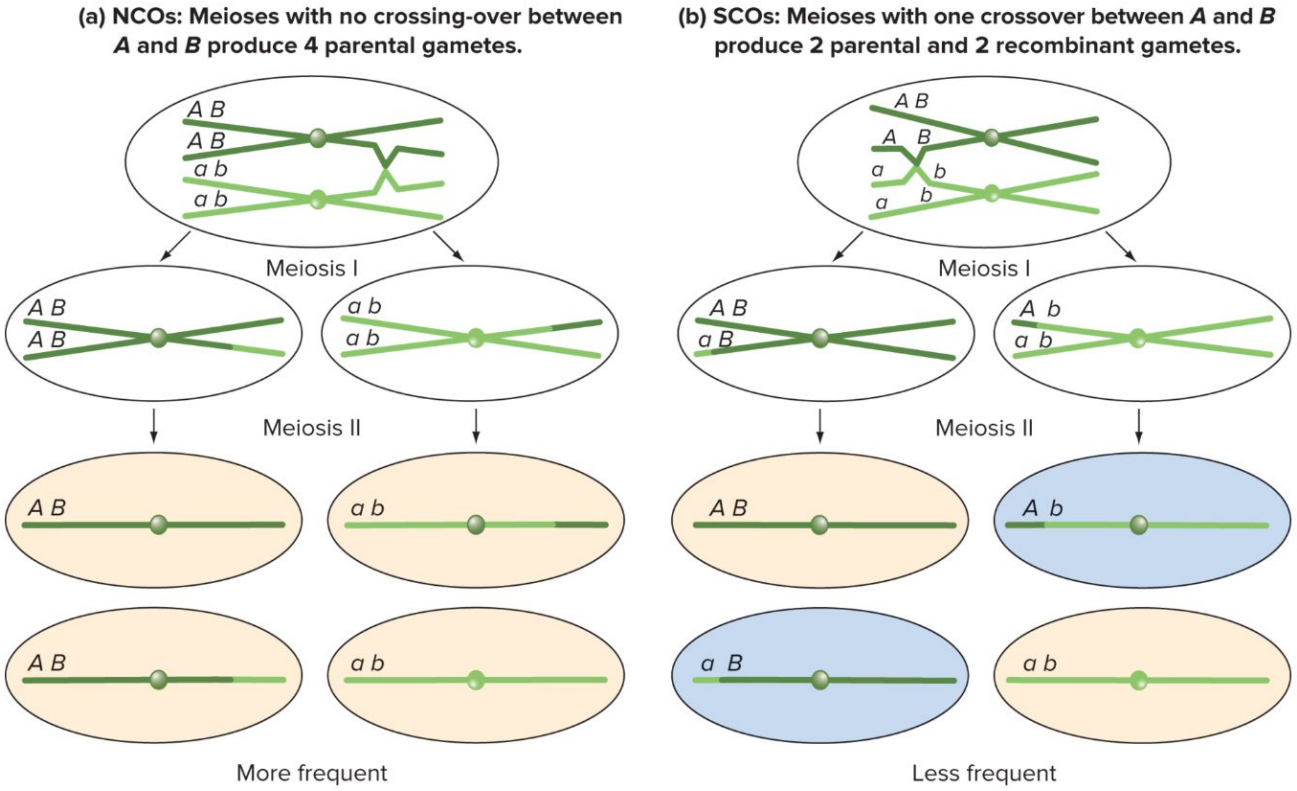


For linked genes to become independent, recombinants must occur between them

NCO - no crossover

SCO - single crossover

Single ~ only one of each chromatid crosses over



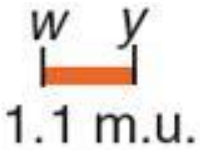
**Recombination rate between sites is proportional to the distance between them

Recombination frequency (RF) can be given as genetic map units (m.u.) or centimorgans (cM)

RF = % chance that two markers on a chromosome will become separated from one another due to a recombination event during meiosis

(a)

RF = 1.1%



1.1 cM

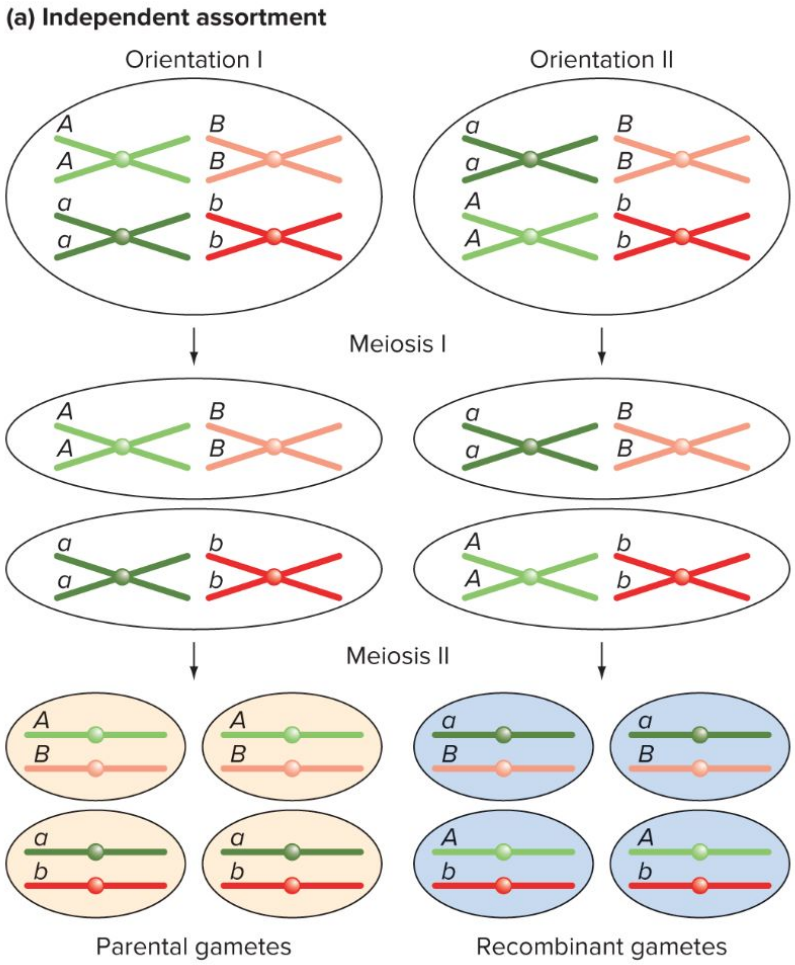
(b)

RF = 32.8%

32.8 cM

For unlinked genes: RF=50%

For unlinked genes, it will look like 50% of gametes are recombinant



How do genetic maps correlate with DNA bp distance

- Map units mean <u>different distances, depending on the organism</u>
  - Human: 1 m.u. = 1,000,000 bp
  - Drosophila melanogaster: 1 cM = 100,000 bp
  - Yeast: 1 m.u. = 2500 bp

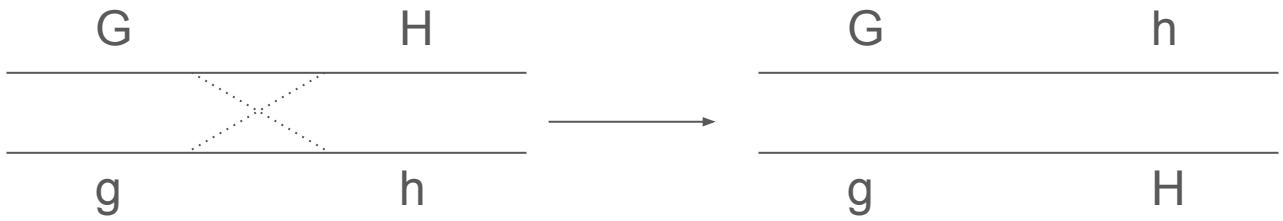
- Physical length depends on recombination rates and length of chromosomes
  - Some organisms recombine more frequently, even with similar genome sizes
    - E.g., Drosophila simulans has 2x the recombination rate of D. melanogaster
  - Organisms with shorter chromosome arms will have shorter map distances
    - Arms must cross over a shorter length

Example recombination question 1

The G and H genes are <u>20 m.u. apart</u> on chromosome 3.
In a population of gametes from a gh/GH individual, what % of chromosome 3s would you expect to be <u>recombinant</u>?

A) 10%
B) 20% ← 20 m.u. = 20% RF
C) 40%
D) 80%

Example recombination question 2

The G and H genes are <u>20 m.u. apart</u> on chromosome 3.
In a population of gametes from a gh/GH individual, what % of chromosome 3s would you expect to be <u>gH recombinants</u>?

A) 10% ← 20 m.u. = 20% RF ⇒ ½ are gH and ½ are Gh ⇒ 10% are gH
B) 20%
C) 40%
D) 80%